

IT Acceptable Use Policy

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1. Purpose

This policy sets out the rules and expectations for the appropriate use of the organisation's information technology systems, devices, networks, software, and digital resources. Its purpose is to protect company data, maintain system security, support efficient working practices, and reduce the risk of disruption, misuse, or unauthorised access.

All employees, consultants, contractors, and temporary staff who use company systems are required to comply with this policy. Access to company systems is provided to support legitimate business activities, and all users are expected to act responsibly, professionally, and securely when using those resources.

This policy should be read alongside other relevant company documents, including the Code of Conduct, Data Protection guidance, and any cyber security procedures issued by the organisation.

2. Scope

This policy applies to all users who access company technology resources, whether using company-issued equipment or approved personal devices. It covers, but is not limited to:

- laptops and desktop computers
- mobile phones and tablets
- email accounts and messaging systems
- internal portals and cloud services
- shared drives and document management systems
- collaboration platforms and communication tools
- internet access and company networks
- software applications, licensed tools, and databases

The policy applies regardless of location. Employees working from the office, from home, or from client sites are all expected to comply with the same standards.

3. General Principles of Acceptable Use

Company technology resources are provided primarily for business use. Users must use these systems in a way that is lawful, secure, responsible, and consistent with their role.

Users are expected to:

- use company systems only for authorised work-related purposes
- protect company, client, and employee information
- comply with security controls and access restrictions
- use company equipment carefully and report faults promptly
- avoid any activity that may damage systems, compromise security, or interfere with other users

Limited personal use may be permitted where it is reasonable, does not affect work performance, does not breach company rules, and does not create security or legal risks. However, company use must always take priority over personal use.

4. User Responsibilities

Each user is responsible for the safe and appropriate use of the systems they access. This includes taking reasonable steps to prevent misuse, accidental disclosure, or damage.

Users must:

- keep login details confidential at all times
- create strong passwords and change them when required
- lock devices when left unattended
- log out of systems when work is complete, especially on shared or public devices
- store files in approved locations rather than unauthorised personal storage services
- ensure sensitive information is only shared with those who are authorised to receive it

Users must not assume that security is solely the responsibility of the IT team. Every individual has a role in protecting company systems and data.

5. Passwords and Account Security

User accounts are issued for individual use only and must never be shared with another person. Passwords are a critical security control and must be created and managed carefully.

Users must:

- use unique passwords that are difficult to guess
- avoid using obvious personal information in passwords
- never write passwords down in insecure locations
- never send passwords by email, chat, or other unprotected methods
- report suspected account compromise immediately

If multi-factor authentication is enabled, users must follow all related security steps. Attempts to bypass account security controls are strictly prohibited.

6. Email and Communication Systems

Company email and communication tools must be used professionally and responsibly. Messages sent through company systems may represent the organisation and must therefore reflect professional standards.

Users must:

- communicate respectfully and appropriately
- check recipients carefully before sending sensitive information
- avoid sending confidential material unless authorised and necessary
- report suspicious emails, links, or attachments
- use company-approved communication channels for work-related discussions

Users must not use company communication systems to send offensive, threatening, discriminatory, misleading, or inappropriate content. Unauthorised mass emails, spam, or excessive personal use are also prohibited.

7. Internet and Web Usage

Internet access is provided to support work-related research, communication, and operational activity. Users should browse responsibly and avoid websites or services that create security, legal, or reputational risks.

Users must not use company internet access to:

- visit illegal, offensive, or inappropriate websites
- download unauthorised software or files
- access pirated, copyrighted, or unsafe content
- engage in activities that could expose the company to malware or cyber threats
- use company resources for personal commercial gain

The organisation may monitor internet usage where necessary to protect systems, investigate security incidents, or ensure compliance with policy.

8. Software and Hardware Use

Only approved software may be installed or used on company devices. This helps ensure compatibility, security, licensing compliance, and operational stability.

Users must not:

- install unauthorised applications
- disable security software or system controls
- connect unapproved external devices that may create security risks
- modify device settings in ways that breach policy or reduce protection

If additional software or equipment is needed for work purposes, the request should be submitted through the appropriate support process. The IT team or authorised personnel will assess the request and determine whether it can be approved.

9. Data Handling and Confidential Information

Company and client information must be handled carefully at all times. Users may have access to confidential, personal, commercial, or operational data and must ensure it is not exposed, lost, or misused.

Users must:

- only access information required for their role
- avoid storing sensitive files in unapproved locations
- share information only with authorised individuals
- follow all data classification and retention rules
- take extra care when working remotely or in public spaces

Confidential information must never be copied, transferred, or disclosed without a legitimate business reason and the necessary permission.

10. Remote Access and Working from External Locations

When accessing systems from outside the office, users must maintain the same security standards as they would on company premises. Remote working and client-site access often create additional risks, so extra care is required.

Users working remotely must:

- use approved access methods such as secure portals or VPN where required
- avoid using public or unsecured Wi-Fi without appropriate protection
- ensure screens are not visible to unauthorised people
- store company devices securely when travelling
- report any lost or stolen equipment immediately

Users should also make sure that printed documents, notes, or screens containing confidential information are not exposed in shared environments.

11. Prohibited Use

The following activities are strictly prohibited:

- sharing login credentials or using another person's account
- attempting to gain unauthorised access to systems or data
- deliberately introducing malware or harmful code
- downloading, installing, or using unapproved software
- using company systems for illegal, fraudulent, or unethical activity
- sending offensive, abusive, discriminatory, or defamatory content
- bypassing company security controls or monitoring measures
- using company technology to support outside business interests without approval

Serious breaches may lead to disciplinary action and, where relevant, legal consequences.

12. Monitoring and Privacy

The organisation reserves the right to monitor the use of company systems where this is necessary for operational, legal, or security reasons. Monitoring may include the review of login activity, system usage, file access, email metadata, internet usage, and other relevant records.

Monitoring is carried out to:

- protect company and client information
- identify suspicious or unauthorised activity
- investigate security incidents or policy breaches
- ensure systems are used appropriately

Users should not expect absolute privacy when using company systems. However, monitoring will be carried out responsibly and in line with applicable laws and company procedures.

13. Reporting Issues and Security Incidents

All users must report IT faults, security concerns, suspicious activity, and suspected policy breaches as soon as possible. Early reporting helps reduce disruption and limits the impact of incidents.

Examples of issues that must be reported include:

- phishing emails or suspicious links
- malware warnings or unusual device behaviour
- lost or stolen devices
- accidental disclosure of confidential information
- unauthorised access attempts
- repeated system outages or login issues

Reports should be made through the company's approved IT support or incident reporting process.

14. Non-Compliance

Failure to comply with this policy may result in action being taken by the organisation. The response will depend on the nature and seriousness of the breach.

Possible consequences include:

- removal or restriction of system access
- mandatory security guidance or retraining
- formal disciplinary action
- escalation to management, HR, or legal teams where necessary

Deliberate misuse, serious negligence, or unlawful activity may be treated as gross misconduct.

15. Policy Review

This policy will be reviewed periodically to ensure that it remains accurate, relevant, and aligned with business needs, security risks, and legal obligations. Updates may be made to reflect changes in technology, working practices, or regulatory requirements.

All users are expected to comply with the most recent version of the policy and may be asked to confirm that they have read and understood it.